On stone benches under a tree outside the museum, I chat with the two guides. They are both from the Dholavira village. They take pride in their village becoming famous by association with the ancient site, but there is also a sense of resentment towards the ASI. The guides claim that the government, at the ASI's behest, forcibly acquired farmland around the site (c. 2012), for which they paid the villagers a mere Rs 2900 per acre. People still farmed this land, beneath which lay more reservoirs of the ancient city. 'The price was an insult,' says the older guide, turning gloomy. 'Better to have given them our land as a gift.' The matter is now in court in another town; the villagers are ill-organized, they have to bear the costs of travel and litigation, and the case might take years or even decades to resolve. The guides also allege that after the digs were done, none of those who worked for years on the digs with Bisht were given permanent government jobs at the site or the museum.

Most guides also resent that all credit for the discovery of Dholavira went to J.P. Joshi of the ASI, with no mention at all of two villagers, Shambhudan Gadhavi, master clerk and amateur geologist, and Velubha Sodha, former sarpanch, who had earlier found the site, picked out some beads and pottery shards, and sent them to the Kutch Museum in 1967. Joshi was then working on Surkotada, a later Harappan site in Gujarat that thrived between 2100 and1700 BCE. Joshi recognized the artefacts from Dholavira at once, and was immortalized by history, even before turning up on site, allege the guides. Despite the enabling work done by others, John Marshall too got all the credit for the discovery of the Harappan Civilization. Such is the way of the world, laments one guide. He asks whether I, in my writing on Dholavira, would help set the record straight.

One afternoon I accompany a guide to the Dholavira village, designated a 'smart village' by the Gujarat government. Outside their dairy cooperative, we run into the sarpanch. Potable water is a huge problem here, he tells me. Some years ago, with the growing use of submersible water pumps, the shallow aquifer on Khadir Island began to go dry. Deeper borewells found only brackish water, unsuitable for all but a few salt-tolerant crops used mostly as livestock feed.

This ecological blow raised the farmers' vulnerability to droughts. Many shifted to raising cows, buffaloes and goats; some farmers and farm labourers migrated out; a few joined the nascent tourist economy and other